2001. The US was concerned that many Taliban had entered across the porous Pak-Afghan border to regroup in Pakistan. There were also instances of the Taliban fighters crossing over from the mostly unmanned Durand Line for rest and respite and returning to Afghanistan to fight again with the US-led forces. It was thought that they were regaining strength with the help of Pakistan's ISI. However, in fact, unlike Al Qaeda, the Taliban was not based in FATA to launch attacks in Afghanistan. They mostly remained in Afghanistan because more than 45 per cent of the Afghan population is Pashtun, which made it more convenient for them to assimilate in their own tribes. Thus, they regrouped in Afghanistan and initiated their guerrilla struggle within two months of their fall. Within five years, they again gained control over much of the eastern and southern parts of Afghanistan.

Nevertheless, Pakistan established hundreds of pickets on the border to check Taliban infiltration. Afghanistan, on the other hand, had less than half of these pickets and had not agreed to Pakistan's suggestion to barricade the entire border.

Surprisingly, the Afghan Taliban survived for a further eight years entirely on hit-and-run operations from FATA and with Pakistan's alleged secret help. It also believed former British Foreign Minister David Miliband's misplaced optimism that the Taliban were 'deeply unpopular' and only 8 per cent of Afghans want the Taliban back. Conversely, the facts showed that Taliban were surviving on local strength and with the support from within, therefore the conflict could continue for a long time. And its intensity had already soared (*The Daily Times*, 2009).

Consequently, Pakistan expressed apprehension of possible Taliban entry into Pakistan, especially after the initiation of Operation 'Panther's Claw' by the British forces and later on the US operation against the Taliban in Helmand in July 2009 (*The Daily Times*, 2009). The US 'assured to take all steps to stop infiltration of fleeing militants into Pakistan' (*The Daily Times*, 2009). Holbrooke also saw little evidence that Taliban fighters had escaped from Helmand into Pakistan. However, he had to discover how the Taliban had melted away within Afghanistan (*The Nation*, 2009).

However, the CIA soon alleged that Mullah Omar was in Pakistan and was harboured by ISI. However, a spokesperson for Foreign Office denied the report as baseless. The Washington Post reported that two senior US intelligence officials and one former senior CIA officer told